The Ashes Before Christ

The letters carved upon their iron saddles do not name common desert raiders. 'BC' is neither a calendar year nor a province: it stands for Before Christ. They are a brotherhood far older than our Order, custodians of a primordial flame that was tended in these lands long before our first observatory was raised.

They believe the stars only reflect what the earth first burned. Their masked leader signs each decree with a seal of soot: a circle cut in two by an iron stroke, the mark of the first flame. They seek the Fourth Chamber, but they do not destroy: they watch, and they leave tokens for the one who walks behind them.

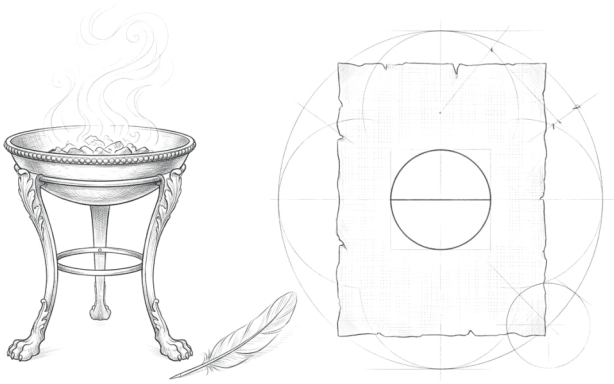


Plate XIII - The bronze tripod brazier and the ancient papyrus. The seal of ash inverts the symbol of the Order.

Hermes found their camp empty at dawn. In the cold embers lay a single golden feather, untouched by the smoke. Weighted beneath an iron rivet rested a folded slip of parchment:

> «Do not mistake our fire for pity, traveler. We kindle the braziers ahead not to guide you, but to test if you can endure our smoke. The dark would have taken you before thirty paces. Gather the nine shards of the living glass: the fourth door yields to no one but the key.»

Hermes' note: A harsh warning, yet he lit every stair ahead of us. Pope-E knew Silvia was following our steps. Why does our pursuer call her the key?